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The Merchant Navy Career Playbook 2027

Class 12 to Captain: the verified route, the real costs, and the scam-proof checklist

Every entry route decoded from DG Shipping and IMU rules

The IMU-CET system, the sponsorship trap, the medical gate

CDC, INDoS, RPSL and Form-1 verification - step by step

Rank-by-rank sea service, COC exams and pay ladders

The 182-day tax rule, welfare rights and the ratings Plan B

35+ PAGES - 19 SECTIONS - 2027 INTAKE

Verified from the Directorate General of Shipping, IMU, the Income Tax Department and PIB - October 2026

HOW TO USE THIS PLAYBOOK

Read this first. It will save you money and time.

This playbook is written for one reader: an Indian student or parent who is seriously considering a career at sea, or an aspirant already partway down the road. It assumes nothing except Class 10 or Class 12 schooling and a willingness to do the reading. Every rule, fee, date and threshold in it is taken from an official source - the Directorate General of Shipping (DG Shipping), the Indian Maritime University (IMU), the Income Tax Department or a Government of India press release - and each section ends by naming where the fact came from.

Two warnings before you begin. First, maritime regulation moves. Dates, fees and eligibility for the 2027 intake will be published on imu.edu.in and dgshipping.gov.in, and you should treat this playbook as the map and those two websites as the ground truth. Where a number is an expectation rather than an announcement, the text says so plainly. Second, the single biggest risk in this career is not the exams - it is a fraudulent agent. Section 10 is the most important chapter in the book. Read it before you pay anyone a rupee.

How the sections fit together

Sections 1 to 2 explain what the industry is and why it is hiring. Sections 3 to 8 are the build: which route to choose, the entrance exam, sponsorship, the medical gate, how to pick an institute, and what it costs. Section 9 gets your official documents right. Section 10 is the fraud defence. Sections 11 to 12 are the career ladder - what you will actually do and earn, rank by rank, deck and engine. Sections 13 to 15 cover money, tax, life at sea and the position of women. Section 16 is your safety net. Section 17 is a dated action plan you can start this week. Section 18 answers forty common questions, and Section 19 lists every official link you will need.

The one-paragraph summary

Get a DG Shipping Class 2 medical before you spend anything. Qualify IMU-CET. Secure a shipping-company sponsorship through a legitimate process. Train only at a DG Shipping-approved institute whose approval is live on the day you pay. Get your CDC and INDoS identity documents online. Sign on only through a licensed RPSL company, and never pay a placement fee - charging one is illegal in India.

CONTENTS

What is inside, section by section

Section 1 - Why the 2027-2030 window is the best in a generation
India is now the world's second-largest supplier of seafarers, and the national target is to reach 20% of the global workforce by 2030. What that means for a young applicant.

Section 2 - What the Merchant Navy actually is
Deck, engine, electro-technical and catering departments; how it differs from the Indian Navy; the shape of a seafaring life.

Section 3 - The officer routes: pick your door
DNS, B.Sc Nautical Science, B.Tech Marine Engineering, GME, ETO and the ratings route, with a side-by-side eligibility table.

Section 4 - IMU-CET: the one exam that unlocks the officer route
The 200-question paper, the syllabus, the -0.25 negative marking, the 2026 timeline and the 2027 expectation.

Section 5 - Sponsorship: the key most aspirants miss
Why company sponsorship, not just a degree, is what actually puts you on a ship, and the legitimate ways to get it.

Section 6 - The medical gate: clear it before you pay anyone
Class 2 and Class 1 medicals, vision and colour-vision rules, and the order in which to do things.

Section 7 - Choosing an institute without getting burned
How to verify a Maritime Training Institute on the DG Shipping list, and what the inspection regime tells you.

Section 8 - What it really costs, and how to fund it
IMU and private-institute fees, the hidden lines, education loans and the scholarships that exist - including for women.

Section 9 - Your identity documents: CDC, INDoS and SID
The step-by-step path to the Continuous Discharge Certificate, fee, validity and the 2026 rule change.

Section 10 - The scam-proof chapter
RPSL verification, Form-1, Form-1A, Form-1B, the eMigrate ARN, the official helpline and the red flags that mean walk away.

Section 11 - Rank by rank: the deck ladder
Cadet to Master. Sea-service requirements, the Certificate of Competency exams and indicative pay.

Section 12 - The engine and electrical ladders
MEO Class IV to Class I and the ETO route, with the 2027 preparatory-course change.

Section 13 - Money and tax: the 182-day reality
How the seafarer day-count rule works, when you become non-resident, and what to keep.

Section 14 - Life at sea: the honest version
Contracts, medical care, welfare programmes, mental health and the things nobody mentions in the brochure.

Section 15 - Women in the Merchant Navy
Where the numbers stand, the support that exists, and the practical realities.

Section 16 - If the officer route does not work
The ratings route, near-coastal options, and the shore careers a sea time opens.

Section 17 - Your 12-month action plan
A dated calendar for a Class 12 student, plus printable checklists.

Section 18 - Forty questions, answered
Eligibility, exams, money, fraud, life - the questions that come up again and again.

Section 19 - Official sources and links
Every government portal and notice referenced in this playbook.

SECTION 1

Why the 2027-2030 window is the best in a generation

India is now the second-largest supplier of seafarers in the world, and the government has set a hard target to become the largest. For a student reading this in 2026, that combination - a strong base and an aggressive national expansion plan - is the strongest hiring signal the Indian maritime sector has produced in decades.

The numbers, from official sources

The BIMCO/ICS Seafarer Workforce Report 2026, cited by the Ministry of Ports, Shipping and Waterways, puts India's contribution at 3,11,936 seafarers - about 12.16% of the global seafaring workforce - behind only the Philippines and ahead of China, Russia and Indonesia. Of that, 1,40,718 are officers (13.41% of the world's officers) and 1,71,218 are ratings. India's global share has more than doubled in a decade: it was 5.2% in 2015, when India ranked fifth.

The report also shows a tight market. Global supply is estimated at about 2.57 million seafarers against demand of about 2.55 million, with a continuing worldwide shortage of qualified officers. A shortage of officers is precisely the gap a well-trained Indian cadet is positioned to fill.

3.12 L
INDIAN SEAFARERS
India's count in the 2026 BIMCO/ICS report, second worldwide

12.16%
GLOBAL SHARE
Up from 5.2% in 2015 - more than doubled in a decade

5.44 L
2030 TARGET
Mission 20%: the national goal for Indian seafarers by 2030

2.17%
WOMEN (2025)
Share of Indian seafarers who are women, up from 0.78% in 2021

Mission 20% - the plan behind the demand

The national strategy is called Mission 20%. Its stated aim is to raise India's share of the global seafaring workforce from about 12% to 20% by 2030 - roughly 5.44 lakh Indian seafarers, an addition of close to 2.21 lakh people and about 68% growth over the 2026 level. That requires growth of roughly 13.9% a year, well above the pace achieved between 2021 and 2026.

To get there, the training pipeline has to expand. Annual maritime training intake has crept up from about 15,400 trainees in 2022 to about 18,800 in 2025 - roughly 8.5% a year. On that trend, throughput would reach only about 29,500 by 2030, which the government's own note says would be insufficient. The conclusion for an applicant is simple: capacity is being pushed up, and the sector needs people.

Why the work matters economically

About 95% of India's trade by volume, and 70% by value, moves by sea. Shipping is not a niche - it is the physical plumbing of the economy. That is why the sector has a long-term policy floor beneath it, expressed in Maritime India Vision 2030 and the longer-horizon Maritime Amrit Kaal Vision 2047.

What this means for you, in one line

A national target of roughly 2.2 lakh additional seafarers by 2030 is the clearest possible statement that India intends to train, certify and employ more people at sea - and that the intake pipeline is being widened, not narrowed.

SECTION 2

What the Merchant Navy actually is

The Merchant Navy is the commercial fleet - cargo ships, tankers, container vessels, bulk carriers, gas carriers and cruise ships - that carries the world's trade. It is not the Indian Navy. The Navy is a branch of the armed forces; the Merchant Navy is a civilian industry, regulated by the Directorate General of Shipping and governed by the Merchant Shipping Act. You wear a uniform and live under discipline, but you are a merchant officer on a commercial contract, not a service officer.

The four departments

Every ship is run by a small, highly structured crew. Your first decision in this career is which department you will join, because it determines the training you take, the exams you sit and the ladder you climb.

Department	What it does	Entry course	Top rank
Deck (Nautical)	Navigation, watchkeeping, cargo operations, safety of the ship	DNS or B.Sc Nautical Science	Master (Captain)
Engine (Marine)	Main engines, machinery, boilers, maintenance, fuel systems	B.Tech Marine Engineering or GME	Chief Engineer
Electro-Technical	Electrical systems, automation, electronics on board	ETO course	Electro-Technical Officer
Catering and ratings	Galley, hospitality, and support deck/engine roles	GP Rating or CCMC	Chief Cook / senior rating

Source: DG Shipping / DGMA career and training pages.

The officer route versus the ratings route

There are two fundamentally different ways in. The officer route starts with a degree or diploma in nautical science or marine engineering, leads to a Certificate of Competency (CoC) and eventually to command. The ratings route starts with a shorter pre-sea course - General Purpose Rating is the common one - and puts you on board sooner in a support role, from which you can, with sea service, work upwards. Officer roles carry the highest pay and responsibility; ratings roles are more accessible after Class 10 or 12. Section 16 covers the ratings route in full.

What a seafaring life is really like

A ship runs on contracts, typically of six to nine months on board, followed by leave ashore. You will cross time zones, work watches around the clock, and live in a small community where your competence is visible every day. The pay is high by Indian standards precisely because the work is remote, structured and sometimes hard. The trade-offs are real: long absences from family, limited connectivity, and the discipline of shipboard hierarchy.

Three things people get wrong

- **It is not the Navy.** Different regulator, different law, different career. If you want the armed forces, that is a separate path with its own exams.
- **A licence is not a job.** A Certificate of Competency qualifies you to serve; it does not by itself place you on a ship. Sponsorship and sea time are what turn a licence into a career.

- **The first job is the hard one.** Entry as a cadet is competitive and depends on sponsorship and sea berths. Plan for it from day one, not after you graduate.

> **A note on the regulator's name**
>
> In 2026 the maritime administration publishes under both the Directorate General of Shipping (dgshipping.gov.in) and the Directorate General of Maritime Administration (dgma.gov.in). This playbook uses DG Shipping throughout; treat the two as the same authority and check both domains for the latest notices.

SECTION 3

The officer routes: pick your door

There is no single road to a merchant navy officer's job. There are several approved routes, and the right one depends on what you have already studied. Choosing correctly at this stage saves years and lakhs of rupees, because each route has a different length, a different entry requirement and a different cost.

The routes, side by side

Route	For	Typical eligibility	Leads to
Diploma in Nautical Science (DNS)	Class 12 PCM students	10+2 with Physics, Chemistry, Maths; about 60% PCM; English 50%; unmarried; age limits	Deck cadet, then Second Mate CoC
B.Sc Nautical Science	Class 12 PCM students	Same as DNS; a 3-year campus programme	Deck officer ladder
B.Tech Marine Engineering	Class 12 PCM students	10+2 PCM, about 60% aggregate	Marine engineer, MEO Class IV
Graduate Marine Engineering (GME)	Engineering graduates	B.E./B.Tech in Mechanical, Naval Architecture or approved allied streams from an AICTE-approved college or IIT	Marine engineer officer
Electro-Technical Officer (ETO)	Electrical/electronics graduates and diploma holders	Degree or diploma in electrical/electronics; 4-month pre-sea ETO course	Electro-Technical Officer CoC
General Purpose Rating (GP Rating)	Class 10 or 12 pass	10th pass with about 40%; a 6-month pre-sea course	Ratings, upgradeable toward officer
Catering (CCMC)	Class 10 or 12 pass	Open to a wider stream; hospitality roles	Galley and hospitality crew

Sources: DG Shipping / DGMA training and career pages; IMU prospectus; Merchant Shipping (STCW) Rules, 2014. Exact cut-offs and age bands vary by institute and year - confirm on the institute's own admission page.

The three rules that decide which door is yours

1. **Physics, Chemistry and Maths in Class 12 open the deck and engine officer routes.** If you did not take PCM, you are not permanently excluded - you can clear the two subjects through the National Institute of Open Schooling or an equivalent, but get any equivalence confirmed with DG Shipping in writing before you pay an institute a deposit.
2. **Your graduation subject decides the engine route.** A Mechanical, Naval Architecture or approved allied engineering degree leads to the one-year GME conversion course. Electrical and electronics graduates go the ETO way. A general science degree without the right subjects will not qualify you for the engine officer ladder on its own.
3. **Age and marital status matter at entry.** Cadet courses typically take candidates between about 17 and 25, and many institutes and sponsoring companies prefer unmarried candidates for cadet intake. Check the current prospectus - these are admission conditions that vary by institute and company.

What changed in 2026 for engineering graduates

The GME route is the fastest door for an engineer who has already finished a degree. In August 2026 the maritime administration placed a draft circular for comment that revises and widens GME eligibility. Under it, candidates with a full-time B.E./B.Tech in Mechanical Engineering, Marine Engineering, Naval Architecture, or in approved allied streams such as Mechatronics and Automobile/Automotive Engineering - from an AICTE-approved institution, an IIT, or a university engineering college - are eligible for the GME course and, on completion, for the Marine Engineer Officer Class IV Certificate of Competency examination. Candidates whose degree falls outside those categories can apply to the Engineering Wing of the administration for an individual assessment of eligibility. Confirm the final, notified version before you enrol.

How to choose, in one minute

Class 12 with PCM and you want command one day? Choose DNS or B.Sc Nautical Science for the deck, or B.Tech Marine Engineering for the engine. Already an engineer? GME (mechanical/naval architecture) or ETO (electrical/electronics). Class 10 or 12 without PCM? The ratings route is open now and is not a dead end.

SECTION 4

IMU-CET: the one exam that unlocks the officer route

If you want the deck or engine officer route, there is one entrance examination you must clear: the Indian Maritime University Common Entrance Test, IMU-CET. This is not optional for the main pre-sea programmes. Under DG Shipping Training Circular 12 of 2020, DG Shipping-regulated Maritime Training Institutes are required to admit candidates on the basis of IMU-CET ranking - and that applies at IMU's own campuses, at affiliated institutes and at approved non-affiliated institutes alike.

The paper, decoded

For the undergraduate technical programmes - DNS, B.Sc Nautical Science, B.Tech Marine Engineering and allied degrees - the exam is a computer-based test of 200 multiple-choice questions, three hours long, in English. Each correct answer scores 1 mark and each wrong answer deducts 0.25. The syllabus is the Class 11 and 12 science stream, with no topics beyond the standard 10+2 curriculum.

Section	Questions	What it tests
Physics	50	Class 11-12 mechanics, electricity, optics, modern physics
Mathematics	50	Algebra, trigonometry, calculus, vectors, probability
Chemistry	25	Physical, inorganic and organic chemistry at 10+2 level
English	25	Comprehension, grammar, vocabulary, idioms
General Knowledge	25	Current affairs, static GK, maritime general knowledge
General Aptitude	25	Reasoning, series, data interpretation, arithmetic
Total	200	Three hours, +1 correct, -0.25 wrong, no negative for blanks

Source: IMU prospectus and CET information brochure. IMU reserves the right to change the distribution and difficulty from year to year.

The 2026 cycle, as it actually ran

The best guide to 2027 is what IMU published for 2026. Registration opened on 5 February 2026 and closed on 24 April, later extended to 28 April. Admit cards came out in mid-May, and the exam was held on 24 May 2026 in two shifts. Results were declared on 14 June, cut-off percentiles followed on 17 June, the first admission list appeared on 25 June, and classes began on 1 August 2026.

For 2027, IMU had not announced the dates as of October 2026. On the 2026 pattern, expect registration to open around February 2027 and the exam to fall in late May 2027 - but treat those as planning assumptions, not announcements. The only authoritative date is the one in IMU's own notice.

The February DNS intake - read this carefully

IMU's 2026-27 prospectus states that the February 2027 DNS batch has no separate entrance test: candidates for it had to sit IMU-CET 2026. If you are reading this hoping to join that batch, the entrance test for it has already happened. Plan for the August 2027 intake instead.

How to actually prepare

The syllabus is school science, so your NCERT Class 11 and 12 books are the foundation - not a coaching brochure. Three moves matter more than anything else.

1. **Respect the negative marking.** At -0.25 a wrong answer, blind guessing is a slow leak of marks. With 200 questions in 180 minutes you have about 54 seconds each; the discipline is to skip cleanly and return, not to guess.
2. **Do not neglect the four 25-mark sections.** English, General Knowledge, General Aptitude and Chemistry together are 100 of the 200 marks - half the paper. Many science students over-invest in Physics and Maths and drop easy marks here.
3. **Take full-length mocks under time.** Three hours on a screen is a stamina test. Simulate it. Track your accuracy per section, not just your total.

The registration fee and process

Registration is online at imu.edu.in, with document upload and online fee payment. Because fees are revised from cycle to cycle, check the current information brochure for the exact amount before you pay. What you can do now is get your documents ready: Class 10 and Class 12 marksheets and certificates, a photograph to specification, your signature, and identity and address proof. IMU has also warned publicly about false information circulating on social media about the CET - the official notice is the only source to trust.

SECTION 5

Sponsorship: the key most aspirants miss

Here is the fact that surprises almost every new aspirant: qualifying IMU-CET and completing a pre-sea course does not, on its own, put you on a ship. For the main cadet programmes, you also need company sponsorship - a shipping company that takes you on as a cadet and provides the structured shipboard training berth your licence depends on. This is where careers are made or quietly stalled.

Why sponsorship exists

A Certificate of Competency is not awarded for classroom study alone. It requires approved sea service, documented in a Training Record Book and a Structured Shipboard Training Programme, performed under qualified officers on board. A training berth on a ship is a scarce, expensive resource. Shipping companies hold them, and they allocate them to the cadets they sponsor. Without a sponsor, a candidate can finish the course and still have no way to accumulate the sea time that turns the qualification into a licence.

The legitimate ways to get sponsored

- **Company cadet selection programmes.** Large shipping and ship-management companies run their own selection - typically an online written test, an interview, and a medical - and then route the selected candidate through IMU-CET and a pre-sea course. This is the standard, transparent route.
- **Institute-linked placement.** Many DG Shipping-approved institutes have standing arrangements with sponsoring companies. Ask an institute directly, before you pay, how many of last year's batch were sponsored, by whom, and what happened to the rest.
- **Direct application to ship-owning and manning companies.** Some companies accept direct cadet applications. Apply widely and keep records of every application.

> **The sponsorship test before you commit**
>
> Ask any institute or agent these four questions in writing: (1) How many cadets did you place with a sponsor in the last two intakes? (2) Which companies sponsored them? (3) What happens to a cadet who qualifies IMU-CET but is not sponsored? (4) Will you confirm in writing that no placement fee is payable by me or my family? An honest operator answers all four without hesitation.

The trap to avoid

Because sponsorship is scarce and valuable, it is the exact point where fraud enters. Unlicensed agents sell 'guaranteed sponsorship' or 'guaranteed placement' for lakhs of rupees. Under Indian rules this is not merely unethical - it is illegal, and the money is very often gone. DG Shipping has repeatedly warned that recruitment must run only through licensed Recruitment and Placement Services Licence (RPSL) companies, and that an RPSL company may not charge a seafarer a placement fee at all. Section 10 covers how to verify this in minutes.

A realistic expectation

Treat sponsorship as the true gate to the profession, and start working on it the same month you start preparing for IMU-CET - not after results. The strongest applications show evidence: a clean medical, a good CET rank, and early, documented contact with companies and institutes. Where a cadet programme bundles sponsorship with training, read the contract's failure, bond and refund clauses before signing, and treat selection or course completion as a step, not a guarantee of a job.

SECTION 6

The medical gate: clear it before you pay anyone

The single most expensive mistake in Indian maritime training is paying a course deposit before confirming you are medically eligible. A medical disqualification discovered after a deposit can cost a family lakhs with no route to a licence. The fix costs a few thousand rupees and a few weeks: get the medical first.

The two medicals, and the order

Medical	Needed for	Done by	Validity
Class 2	Entering training and the student stage	A DG Shipping-authorised medical examiner	Typically 24 months for candidates under 40
Class 1	Exercising CPL or officer privileges	DG Shipping-authorised medical assessment centres	Typically 12 months for those under 40

Source: DG Shipping medical standards and training pages. Validity bands change with age and are revised from time to time - confirm your own case with an authorised examiner.

Do Class 2 first, then Class 1 immediately

Class 2 is the entry gate: you need it before you register and before flight or simulator training begins. But Class 2 only lets you start. Class 1 is the full commercial standard, and it is the one that actually decides whether you can serve as an officer. The practical advice from every credible source is to complete an initial Class 1 early - before you commit serious money - so a problem surfaces while it is still cheap to change course.

What actually fails people

- **Colour vision deficiency is the hard stop.** Any degree of colour blindness, including the common red-green type, is treated as disqualifying for unrestricted commercial operations. There is no corrective procedure that changes this. Test it early with an Ishihara check.
- **Wearing glasses does not disqualify you,** provided corrected visual acuity meets the standard and your refractive error falls within the prescribed limits.
- **Deck and engine standards differ.** The deck side typically requires 6/6 unaided vision; the engine side is more permissive on corrected vision. Colour vision is a barrier on both.
- **Many findings are 'temporarily unfit', not a permanent rejection.** These come with a defined window to treat and re-present. Read the certificate carefully before assuming the worst.

> **The cheapest decision you will make**
>
> Book a Class 2 medical - or at the very least an Ishihara colour-vision test - in your final school year. It costs a few thousand rupees and settles the question before a single lakh is committed to a course.

Fitness is ongoing, not once

A medical is not a one-time ticket. Class 1 medicals are renewed periodically, and a Certificate of Competency must be revalidated every five years with evidence of continued competence and medical fitness. Build the habit of keeping your medicals current from the start; an expired certificate at the wrong moment can cost you a contract.

SECTION 7

Choosing an institute without getting burned

The difference between a DG Shipping-approved Maritime Training Institute and an institute that merely calls itself one is the difference between a career and a court case. Thousands of aspirants have lost money to institutes that claimed an approval they did not have. The check that prevents this takes two minutes and costs nothing.

Verify, in this order

1. **Check the official list.** Go to dgshipping.gov.in and open the Maritime Training / Training Branch section, then 'Approved Training institutes'. Confirm the institute appears and that the specific course you are paying for is on the approved-course list. Do not accept a screenshot, a framed certificate or a logo on the institute's own website.
2. **Check the course, not just the institute.** An institute may be approved for some courses and not others. Look up the exact programme - DNS, B.Sc Nautical Science, B.Tech Marine Engineering, GME, ETO, GP Rating - and confirm it is listed.
3. **Check the current status on the day you pay.** DG Shipping publishes show-cause notices, suspension orders and withdrawal orders. An institute can lose approval after you have signed up. Re-check immediately before any payment, and keep a dated copy.
4. **Verify your own certificate afterwards.** Once you complete a course, you can confirm the certificate's authenticity on the DG Shipping INDoS/CoP checker by selecting the STCW course option and entering your details.

What the inspection regime tells you

In 2026 the administration ordered a Mandatory Comprehensive Inspection Programme (CIP) for all DG Shipping-approved Maritime Training Institutes, and publishes CIP reports and MTI performance results. A responsible institute expects inspection and can speak to it. Ask an institute for its latest inspection outcome, its student-to-aircraft or student-to-simulator ratio, and the average time its recent students took to complete training.

The scale of the problem

The scale is large. In early 2026 the Sailors' Union of India publicly estimated that more than 1,000 unrecognised institutes were operating across the country, and in one documented case a Delhi academy was advertising courses including B.Tech Marine Engineering, B.Sc Nautical Science, DNS, GP Rating, GME and ETO while claiming a DG Shipping approval that the regulator publicly stated it did not have. That case, reported by national media in February 2026, is the clearest illustration of why verification is not optional.

Three questions that expose a bad institute

1. Can you show me your institute and this exact course on the DG Shipping approved list right now, on the government site? 2. What is your latest CIP inspection outcome? 3. How many of last year's students are actually at sea, and with which companies? Evasion on any of the three is your answer.

Read the contract before you sign

Approval settles whether an institute is legitimate; the contract settles what you have agreed to. Before paying, read and keep a copy of the fee schedule, the refund policy, the consequences of failing an exam, what happens if training takes longer than advertised, and whether any equipment, uniform or examination cost sits outside the headline fee. A reputable institute states these in writing. An operator who resists putting them in writing is telling you something.

SECTION 8

What it really costs, and how to fund it

Maritime training is expensive, and the headline number is almost never the whole number. A family that budgets only the advertised course fee will be caught out by ground school, examinations, medicals, living costs and the type rating or advanced courses that come later. Plan the whole journey, not the first instalment.

The cost structure

IMU publishes its own annual programme fee for its campuses, and private affiliated institutes set their own. As a planning reference, IMU's 2026-27 prospectus listed the annual fee for its DNS, B.Sc Nautical Science and B.Tech Marine Engineering programmes at about Rs 2,75,000, made up of a programme fee and per-semester charges, with a counselling fee and a refundable caution deposit on top. Private institutes vary widely above and below this. Confirm the current figures on imu.edu.in and the institute's own fee page before you budget.

Cost line	What it covers	Watch for
Programme fee	Tuition across the course	Per-semester vs per-year billing; IMU and private rates differ
Ground school and exam fees	Coaching and DG Shipping exam charges	Re-attempt fees add up if a subject is failed
Medicals	Class 2, Class 1 and renewals	Travel to authorised centres
Study material and equipment	Books, charts, navigation tools, uniform	Often quoted separately
Living costs	Hostel, mess, travel	18-24 months on the deck route
Later: type rating and advanced courses	Aircraft-type or advanced STCW modules	Comes after the licence, not in the headline

Figures are planning ranges from official fee pages and market reporting; treat them as indicative and verify current rates directly.

Funding it

Secured education loans are the standard route, and several banks offer education-loan products that can be used for maritime training, often against collateral. Start the loan process weeks before an admission deadline, not days - processing takes time. The store's companion Education Loan Playbook covers the mechanics of Indian education loans in detail.

The scholarships that exist

The most concrete support in this sector is aimed at women. Under the Sagar Mein Samman initiative, the Maritime Training Trust offers support of up to Rs 1,00,000 to women cadets and ratings undertaking pre-sea courses. Separately, watch for state-level schemes and any airline or shipping-company cadet programmes that offset fees. Check the DG Shipping welfare pages and the Maritime Training Trust for current eligibility and application windows, and apply early - these are competitive.

The funding sequence that protects you

1. Medical first (few thousand rupees). 2. Build a full budget, including living costs and a 10-15% buffer, not just the course fee. 3. Get itemised quotations from at least three approved institutes. 4. Start the education-loan application early. 5. Pay in milestones tied to training stages, never the full amount upfront. 6. Treat any demand for the whole fee in cash before training as a red flag.

SECTION 9

Your identity documents: CDC, INDoS and SID

Before you can work at sea you need an identity as a seafarer. The key document is the Continuous Discharge Certificate - the CDC - a booklet that records every ship you join and leave, and which is internationally recognised as your seafarer identity and service record. Getting it right, early and accurately, avoids years of paperwork pain.

The Continuous Discharge Certificate (CDC)

The CDC is issued by the Shipping Master through the Government Shipping Offices at Mumbai, Chennai and Kolkata. Applications are made online and the certificate is dispatched by post; in most cases you do not visit the office in person unless told to.

CDC - key facts	Detail
Issuing authority	Shipping Master, Government Shipping Offices - Mumbai, Chennai, Kolkata
Eligibility	Indian citizen; at least 18; passed Class 10; valid DGS medical; basic STCW safety courses completed at an approved institute
Required STCW basics	PST or PSCRB; FPFF or AFF; EFA, MFA or MC; PSSR; STSDSD or SSO
Fee	Rs 700 (non-refundable), payable online
Validity	10 years; renewable on or before expiry
2026 change	DGS Order No. 12 of 2026 revises CDC eligibility and seafarer quality standards with effect from 1 August 2026

Source: DG Shipping / DGMA CDC and Seamen Employment Office pages; Merchant Shipping (CDC) Rules, 2017.

Documents to have ready

- Passport-sized photograph to the specified size, on a white background
- Scanned signature
- Colour scan of your passport's personal-details pages
- Class 10 pass certificate or marksheet
- Medical fitness certificate from a DG Shipping-approved doctor
- Permanent address proof - passport, Aadhaar, voter ID or permanent driving licence

INDoS - your seafarer number

INDoS is the Indian National Database of Seafarers. Every seafarer is registered in DG Shipping's e-Governance system, and your INDoS number is your user identity for almost everything that follows - CDC applications, sea-service records, examination applications and the verification that airlines and immigration perform. Registration is done on the DG Shipping website under e-Governance; your user ID and password are emailed to you, usually within 24 hours.

Keep your INDoS profile accurate

Your name, date of birth and passport details must match your Class 10 certificate and passport exactly. Mismatches are the most common cause of rejected applications and of delays at immigration. If any detail is wrong, correct it in the INDoS database before applying for anything else - there is a defined process for this through the Shipping Master.

SID and the paper trail

The Seafarers Identity Document (SID) draws on the CDC and INDoS records, which is another reason to keep both clean. From the moment you have them, treat your CDC, passport and INDoS credentials as your professional identity. Never hand your passport or CDC to an unknown person, and never let an agent hold them. Section 10 explains why this is not a small caution.

SECTION 10

The scam-proof chapter

If you read only one section of this playbook, read this one. Fraudulent recruitment is the defining hazard of an Indian maritime career, and it is organised, persistent and costly. DG Shipping has documented the problem at length, issued a formal advisory, and built tools to let you verify an agency in minutes. Use them.

What the regulator says, in its own words

In a 2025 circular the Directorate General of Shipping recorded that it had noted 'with serious concern the increasing number of complaints received from seafarers who have been cheated, misled, or financially exploited by unauthorized recruitment and placement agents under the pretext of offering jobs on foreign-flagged vessels.' The circular lists the consequences: no support during accidents, injuries, medical emergencies or stranding; no help in wage disputes; and, critically, that sea service obtained through unregistered agents is invalid and cannot be uploaded into the government system.

The single rule that protects you

Recruitment of Indian seafarers must be carried out only through a company holding a valid Recruitment and Placement Services Licence - an RPSL - issued under the Merchant Shipping (Recruitment and Placement of Seafarers) Rules, 2016. And an RPSL company may not charge a seafarer a recruitment or placement fee; its income comes from the ship-owning or manning company. Charging a seafarer a placement fee is illegal in India.

The three checks, in three minutes

1. Verify the RPSL. DG Shipping maintains a live, continuously updated status showing whether a licence is valid, invalid or temporarily blocked. Engage only with companies whose status is Valid. 2. Confirm the Form. Every seafarer joining a vessel must carry a genuine, system-generated Form-1 (foreign-flag vessels via an RPSL), Form-1A (Indian-flag vessels) or Form-1B (non-seafarer categories). 3. Check the ARN. The eMigrate Application Reference Number on the form is linked to your passport by the Protector General of Emigrants, and immigration verifies that link live at departure.

The forms, and why they changed

A 2025 circular replaced the old editable Form-1 with three standardised forms, each carrying security features - a non-editable PDF, an embedded DG Shipping logo watermark, an eMigrate reference-number watermark and a unique auto-generated serial number. The three forms are: Form-1 for Indian seafarers recruited through RPSL companies for foreign-flag vessels; Form-1A for those recruited through RPSL companies or Indian shipowners for Indian-flag vessels; and Form-1B for non-seafarer categories such as supernumeraries, technicians, auditors and surveyors. An altered, handwritten or unofficial form will be rejected at the airport.

Your rights as a key worker

Under Section 56(3) of the Merchant Shipping Act, 2025, seafarers are deemed 'key workers', to ease their safe and unhindered movement during embarkation and disembarkation, shore leave, and shore-based medical treatment. If an airline or an immigration counter wrongly blocks you for not producing an outdated form, that is a reportable problem - and the administration has set up a 24x7 channel for exactly this.

Official help channels - save these now

Email: support.dgs@gov.in and crews.dgs@gov.in. Phone or WhatsApp: +91 90040 48406 and +91 86575 49760. These channels are published by DG Shipping for seafarers. Report fraudulent recruitment, denial of boarding, or any demand for a placement fee.

The red flags - walk away

- **A guarantee of a job or sponsorship in exchange for money.** Placement fees charged to a seafarer are illegal, full stop.
- **A demand for payment into a personal bank account.** Legitimate companies do not collect placement money from seafarers at all.
- **A request to hand over your passport or CDC 'for processing'.** Never surrender these to an individual.
- **An offer through WhatsApp or social media from an unverified contact.** DG Shipping specifically warns against informal channels.
- **A company whose RPSL status is invalid or temporarily blocked.** No interaction, no documents, no payment, no offer.
- **A Form-1 that is edited, handwritten or not system-generated.** It will fail at the airport and may be treated as fraud.
- **Pressure to travel without proper documentation.** This is how people end up stranded abroad.

If you have already paid

Act quickly. Preserve every message, receipt, bank transfer record and form. Report to DG Shipping on the channels above and to your local police. The regulator has a stated zero-tolerance policy toward agencies engaged in fraudulent practices, including blocking their online privileges, auditing them, suspending or withdrawing the licence, and debarring directors from maritime activity for five years. There is also a grievance mechanism that triggers investigation. The earlier the report, the more that can be done.

SECTION 11

Rank by rank: the deck ladder

The deck officer's career is a ladder with fixed rungs, and each rung has a sea-service requirement and an examination attached to it. Understanding the ladder before you start tells you what you are working towards and roughly when you will reach it. Everything below is drawn from DG Shipping and DGMA nautical-examination rules and the Merchant Shipping (STCW) Rules, 2014.

The rungs

Rank	Certificate (CoC)	Sea-service requirement	Indicative pay / month
Deck Cadet	Trainee	Structured shipboard training, 12-18 months, with Training Record Book	Rs 25,000 - 80,000 (stipend)
Third Officer	Second Mate FG (STCW II/1)	12 months approved sea service with 6 months bridge watchkeeping	Rs 1.0 - 2.0 lakh
Second Officer	Second Mate FG	Additional sea service as watchkeeping officer	Rs 2.0 - 3.5 lakh
Chief Officer	Chief Mate FG (STCW II/2)	18 months approved sea service as watchkeeping officer	Rs 3.5 - 5.5 lakh
Master (Captain)	Master FG (STCW II/2)	3 years as officer in charge of a navigational watch, reducible to 30 months with 1 year as Chief Mate	Rs 5.0 - 8.0 lakh and above

Sea-service figures are the regulatory minimums under the STCW Rules; pay bands are indicative market ranges that vary widely by company, vessel type, flag and nationality of crew. Always confirm your own sea-service position with an assessment centre (MMD).

How the exams work

The Certificate of Competency examinations are conducted by the administration at MMD centres in Mumbai, Chennai and Kolkata, and each level combines written papers with an oral assessment. You apply for an eligibility assessment online - through the e-Samudra portal - where your sea service from RPSL companies and your training certificates from MTIs are checked against the STCW requirements. On approval, a Form 29 is generated for submission at the MMD with original documents, and a seat is allotted for the written and oral examination.

Sea service is not all equal

Not every month at sea counts the same. DG Shipping rules require that a substantial part of your sea service be performed on trading vessels of a specified tonnage, and time on non-trading or special-purpose vessels is credited at reduced rates - often two-thirds or half, with caps. A cadet who spends years on the wrong kind of vessel can find that the hours do not add up to eligibility. Confirm, in writing, the type of vessel a sponsor intends to place you on, and keep your own running total against the licensing requirement.

Keep your own logbook

Your Training Record Book and logbook are the evidence of your career. Track every sign-on and sign-off yourself, in parallel with the official record, and check that each voyage appears in your INDoS profile. If a voyage is missing, raise it early - the longer it sits, the harder it is to fix.

SECTION 12

The engine and electrical ladders

The engine department runs the machinery that moves the ship; the electro-technical department runs its electrical, electronic and automation systems. Both are strong careers, and both are changing in 2026 and 2027 - so a candidate entering now should know the current rules.

The engine ladder

Marine engineer officers progress through Marine Engineer Officer (MEO) grades: MEO Class IV, then Class II, then Class I, roughly mirroring the deck ladder in seniority. Entry into the ladder depends on your prior qualification. A Class 12 PCM student takes the four-year B.Tech Marine Engineering route. A mechanical or naval architecture graduate takes the one-year GME conversion course, and, under the 2026 draft eligibility circular, graduates of approved allied streams may also qualify - with an individual assessment available for borderline degrees. A marine engineer officer's pay climbs with grade, from the entry level into the lakhs per month at senior grades.

What changed for 2027

A 2026 circular introduces mandatory preparatory courses for MEO Class IV and Electro-Technical Officer CoC examinations. The requirement applies to all candidates applying for eligibility assessment or appearing for the MEO Class IV written or oral examination for the first time on or after 1 January 2027, and to a defined set of returning candidates. Approved institutes were able to seek approval and begin the preparatory courses from 1 November 2026. If you are targeting a first attempt in 2027, budget for the preparatory course and confirm with your institute that it is approved to run it.

The electro-technical route

The Electro-Technical Officer (ETO) is responsible for a ship's electrical and electronic systems. The entry course is a four-month pre-sea ETO course at a DG Shipping-approved institute, open to candidates with an electrical or electronics degree or diploma. The qualification requirements and progression rules were refined through 2026.

A note on the ETR-to-ETO pathway

There is a defined progression for Electro-Technical Ratings (ETR) into the ETO role. A rating with an ETR Certificate of Proficiency can, after accumulating the required sea service, join the four-month ETO pre-sea course and then sit the ETO CoC examination. The age limit that once applied to such candidates has been removed. The sea-service requirement differs depending on whether you hold a diploma or degree in electrical or electronics, so check the current circular for the exact months before you plan.

And a newer bridge - ETO to engineer

A 2026 circular establishes a structured transition pathway for certified ETOs to obtain a Marine Engineer Officer Class IV CoC. It requires, among other things, a valid ETO CoC, not less than 24 months of approved seagoing service as an ETO on ships of 750 kW or more, a DGMA-approved three-month bridging course, a completed Training and Assessment Record Book, and an engine-room simulator course - followed by onboard training and examinations. It is a demanding route, but it exists now where it did not before, which matters if you are choosing a specialisation early.

Choosing between engine and electrical

If you like machinery, thermodynamics and heavy systems, the engine ladder is the fit. If you like electronics, control systems and automation - and want a faster entry through the four-month ETO course - the electro-technical route is the one. Both lead to senior officer pay; both now carry preparatory or bridging requirements, so build them into your timeline.

SECTION 13

Money and tax: the 182-day reality

Seafaring has a tax dimension that few other careers have, and it is worth understanding early - because a seafarer who spends enough of the year outside India can legitimately be treated as a non-resident, and the difference in tax is substantial. The rule that makes this work for crew is specific, and it depends on your CDC.

The residence threshold

Under Indian income-tax law, an individual is generally resident in India for a year if present in India for 182 days or more in that year, or for 60 days or more in the year together with 365 days or more in the preceding four years. For an Indian citizen who leaves India as a member of the crew of an Indian ship, the 60-day figure is replaced by 182 days. Where a person is not resident, the scope of taxable income narrows to income received in, or accruing or arising in, India.

The seafarer day-count rule

This is the provision that matters most to you. For an Indian citizen who is a member of the crew of a foreign-bound ship, the period of an eligible voyage is excluded from the count of days of stay in India. The excluded period runs from the date entered in your Continuous Discharge Certificate for joining the ship to the date entered for signing off. An eligible voyage is one carrying passengers or freight in international traffic, where either the voyage originates at an Indian port and ends at a foreign port, or originates abroad and ends at an Indian port.

> **Your CDC is your tax evidence**
>
> The dates in your Continuous Discharge Certificate are what fix the excluded period. Keep every CDC entry for every voyage, and keep the certificate itself safe. Without the record, you cannot demonstrate the exclusion - which is precisely why an unregistered agent's sea service, which never reaches the government system, is worthless on two counts: it is not valid for your licence, and it is not evidence for your tax position.

What this means in practice

A seafarer on foreign-going voyages can accumulate enough excluded days to fall below the 182-day residence threshold and be treated as non-resident for the year, with the tax consequences that follow. But this is a fact-sensitive area - your exact status depends on your total days, your voyage pattern and the year - so treat this section as orientation, not advice. The rules were re-enacted in the Income-tax Act, 2025 framework with the seafarer day-count rule carried forward. For your own return, use a qualified chartered accountant who handles seafarer or NRI cases, and keep your CDC entries, contracts and bank records organised by financial year.

The practical money habits

- Keep a digital copy and a physical copy of every CDC page, every contract and every sign-on and sign-off record.
- Maintain a clear record of remittances into India, separated by year.
- Track your days in India against the 182-day line through the year, not at the end of it.
- Do not rely on informal advice from a crew mess or a WhatsApp group on a question this consequential.

SECTION 14

Life at sea: the honest version

A playbook that sells only the salary is doing you no favours. Life at sea is genuinely rewarding and genuinely hard, and the things that make it hard are known and, increasingly, supported by the regulator. Go in with your eyes open.

The rhythm of the work

Contracts typically run several months on board, followed by leave ashore. On board you stand watches - a rotating shift pattern covering the 24-hour operation of the ship - and you live in a small, hierarchical community where your work is visible and your competence matters. Connectivity has improved but is not guaranteed; family separation is the real cost of the career, not the physical work.

Welfare is now a formal priority

DG Shipping recognises seafarers as key workers and has put crew welfare at the centre of its agenda. Two programmes are worth knowing. Sagar Mein Yog addresses ten dimensions of seafarer wellness, from physical and mental health to social and spiritual well-being. Sagar Mein Samman is the gender-inclusion drive for women in shipping. There is also a grievance-redressal mechanism for complaints about working or living conditions, and RPSL agencies are required to maintain records of complaints received.

Medical care, injury and emergencies

This is where the difference between a licensed and an unlicensed channel becomes stark. DG Shipping's own advisory notes that seafarers recruited through unauthorised agents face a lack of support during accidents, injuries, medical emergencies and stranding, and no intervention in wage disputes. When you sail through a valid RPSL company, there is a defined system: a Seafarer Employment Agreement or Collective Bargaining Agreement, protection under the Maritime Labour Convention, and a regulator with jurisdiction over the agency. That structure is not paperwork - it is what stands between you and being abandoned in a foreign port.

Before every sign-on, confirm four things

1. The RPSL company's status is Valid on the DG Shipping site. 2. You hold a genuine, system-generated Form-1 or Form-1A with a correct eMigrate ARN linked to your passport. 3. You have your Seafarer Employment Agreement or equivalent. 4. You have the DG Shipping help numbers saved and know how to use them from abroad.

Mental health, honestly

Long contracts, isolation and disrupted sleep are real stressors, and the industry has begun to acknowledge them openly rather than treat them as weakness. If you are struggling on board, use the ship's reporting channels and, where relevant, the welfare structures above. If you are considering this career and know that extended isolation is difficult for you, weigh that honestly against the pay - it is a legitimate factor in the decision.

SECTION 15

Women in the Merchant Navy

Women remain a small minority of Indian seafarers, but the trend line is the steepest in the sector, and the policy support is explicit. If you are a young woman considering this career, the numbers below describe where the industry is - and where the government says it is going.

Where the numbers stand

The share of women among Indian seafarers rose from 0.78% in 2021 to 2.17% in 2025 - growth of roughly 340% in the number of women seafarers within four years. In absolute terms, the count moved from about 1,600 in 2021 to roughly 7,000 in 2025. Over a longer horizon, women seafarer registrations rose from 1,669 in 2015 to 14,255 in 2024. Maritime India Vision 2030 targets a share of 2% to 3%, a band India has already reached on the 2025 figure.

The support that exists

The clearest financial support is the Maritime Training Trust scholarship of up to Rs 1,00,000 for women cadets and ratings undertaking pre-sea courses, delivered under the Sagar Mein Samman initiative. Beyond money, the programme sets out to address the structural barriers - awareness, onboard gender sensitisation, and onboarding support for women entering the profession - and the administration runs outreach and scholarship programmes specifically to widen participation.

If you are a young woman applying

Apply for the Maritime Training Trust support early and check the current eligibility and window on the DG Shipping welfare pages. Choose an institute with a demonstrated record of placing women cadets, and ask directly about onboard arrangements and company policies before you commit. The community of women seafarers in India is growing and organised - connecting with it before you sail is worth the effort.

The honest caveat

Government documents themselves describe the barriers in plain terms: limited awareness of opportunities, a lack of incentives from some shipping companies, and prevailing cultural resistance. The trend is strongly positive and the direction of policy is unambiguous, but a woman entering this field should expect to be an early mover in some companies and should choose her sponsors and institutes with the same care - arguably more - as anyone else. Section 10's verification steps apply to you exactly as they do to everyone.

SECTION 16

If the officer route does not work

Not everyone will clear IMU-CET, secure a sponsor or fund a degree course, and that is not the end of a maritime career. The ratings route is a real, legitimate way into the industry, and a sea career opens shore doors that many people never consider.

The ratings route

General Purpose Rating is the common entry point. It is a six-month pre-sea course open to candidates who have passed Class 10, typically with around 40% in English, science and mathematics. It does not require IMU-CET in the way the officer programmes do. A rating starts on board sooner, in a support role, and can, with sea service and further certification, progress toward officer qualifications - including near-coastal officer certificates and, with additional sea time, foreign-going examinations. It is a slower road, not a closed one.

Route	Entry requirement	Course	Where it can lead
General Purpose Rating	Class 10 pass (about 40%)	6-month pre-sea	Deck or engine ratings; upgrade path
Catering (CCMC)	Class 10 or 12 pass, wider stream	Catering course	Galley and hospitality crew
Near-coastal officer (NCV)	Varies; sea service based	Approved competency course	Officer on near-coastal voyages

Source: DG Shipping training pages and the STCW Rules; confirm current eligibility with the institute.

The shore careers a sea time opens

Sea experience is unusually transferable. Ship management, marine surveying, port operations, maritime law, classification societies, marine insurance, chartering and maritime training all draw heavily on people who have served at sea, and the regulator itself uses sea-experienced officers for examiner and surveyor posts. Even a short sea career builds competence that shoreside employers value, which is a good reason not to think of this as an all-or-nothing decision.

The Plan B principle

Treat the ratings route and the shore-career exit as designed parts of your plan, not failures. The people who do well in this industry are usually the ones who understood, from the beginning, that there is more than one way in and more than one way to use the experience afterwards.

SECTION 17

Your 12-month action plan

This section turns everything above into a dated sequence. It assumes you are in Class 12 in the 2026-27 academic year and aiming at the 2027 intake. Adjust the months if you are on a different timeline - the order matters more than the exact dates.

The calendar

When	What to do	Why it matters now
Nov - Dec 2026	Get a Class 2 medical, or at minimum an Ishihara colour-vision test. Build a written budget with a 10-15% buffer.	Settles eligibility before any money is committed
Dec 2026 - Jan 2027	Shortlist institutes. Verify each on the DG Shipping approved list. Start IMU-CET preparation from NCERT.	Verification is free and prevents the biggest loss
Jan - Feb 2027	Watch imu.edu.in for the IMU-CET 2027 notification. Gather marksheets, photo and signature to specification.	The registration window is short and extensions are not guaranteed
Feb - Apr 2027	Register for IMU-CET. Apply for cadet selection programmes at shipping companies. Start any education-loan application.	Loan processing takes weeks; company selection runs in parallel
Apr - May 2027	Sit IMU-CET. Attend company interviews and medicals. Confirm sponsorship arrangements in writing.	Sponsorship is the true gate to a ship
Jun - Jul 2027	Results and counselling. Accept a seat only after re-checking the institute's approval status that day.	Approval can lapse; re-check before paying
Aug 2027	Course begins. Register your INDoS profile and keep your documents clean.	Your seafarer identity starts here
Ongoing	Track sea service, keep every CDC entry, revalidate medicals, never pay a placement fee.	Protects your licence and your tax position

Printable checklists

Before you pay any institute or agent

- Class 2 medical cleared (or booked).
- Institute and course confirmed on the DG Shipping approved list, today.
- Latest inspection outcome and placement record requested in writing.
- Full fee schedule and refund policy in writing.
- No placement fee payable by me or my family - confirmed in writing.

Before every sign-on

- RPSL company status checked and Valid.
- Genuine Form-1 or Form-1A with a correct eMigrate ARN linked to my passport.
- Seafarer Employment Agreement or equivalent in hand.
- CDC, passport and INDoS details accurate and matching.
- DG Shipping help numbers saved for use from abroad.

The five rules to carry with you

1. Medical before money. 2. Verify every institute on the government list. 3. Never pay a placement fee - it is illegal. 4. Sign on only through a valid RPSL company. 5. Keep your own record of every voyage.

SECTION 18

Forty questions, answered

These are the questions that come up again and again from aspirants and parents. The answers are short and, where a rule applies, they point you to the source.

Q1. Is the Merchant Navy the same as the Indian Navy?
No. The Merchant Navy is the civilian commercial fleet, regulated by the Directorate General of Shipping under the Merchant Shipping Act. The Indian Navy is a branch of the armed forces with a separate selection process.

Q2. What is the minimum education to start?
Class 10 for the ratings route (General Purpose Rating). Class 12 with Physics, Chemistry and Maths for the officer routes - DNS, B.Sc Nautical Science and B.Tech Marine Engineering.

Q3. I did not take Physics and Maths in Class 12. Am I out?
Not necessarily. Candidates without PCM can clear the two subjects through the National Institute of Open Schooling or an equivalent route, but get any equivalence confirmed with DG Shipping in writing before paying an institute a deposit.

Q4. Is IMU-CET compulsory?
Yes for the main pre-sea officer programmes. Under DG Shipping Training Circular 12 of 2020, DG Shipping-regulated institutes admit candidates on IMU-CET ranking - at IMU campuses, affiliated institutes and approved non-affiliated institutes alike.

Q5. How many questions and how much negative marking?
200 multiple-choice questions in three hours for the UG technical programmes, with +1 for a correct answer and -0.25 for a wrong one. There is no deduction for an unattempted question.

Q6. What is the syllabus?
The Class 11 and 12 science stream: Physics, Mathematics, Chemistry, plus English, General Knowledge and General Aptitude at a comparable level. No topics beyond the standard 10+2 curriculum.

Q7. When is IMU-CET 2027?
IMU had not announced the 2027 dates as of October 2026. On the 2026 pattern, expect registration around February 2027 and the exam in late May 2027 - planning assumptions only. The official notice is the only authority.

Q8. How much does the course cost?
It varies by institute. As a reference, IMU's 2026-27 prospectus listed about Rs 2,75,000 a year for its DNS, B.Sc Nautical Science and B.Tech Marine Engineering programmes, plus counselling and a refundable caution deposit. Private institutes differ; confirm current rates directly.

Q9. Is a medical needed before joining?
Yes. A Class 2 medical is needed to begin training, and a Class 1 medical is needed to exercise officer privileges. Get at least a Class 2 - ideally an early Class 1 - before committing money.

Q10. Will wearing glasses disqualify me?
Not by itself. Corrected visual acuity must meet the standard and refractive error must fall within prescribed limits. Colour vision deficiency, however, is a hard disqualification on both deck and engine sides.

Q11. What is sponsorship and do I really need it?

It is a shipping company taking you on as a cadet and providing the shipboard training berth your licence depends on. For the main cadet programmes, you need it - qualifying the exam and completing the course is not enough on its own.

Q12. How do I know an institute is genuine?
Check it on the DG Shipping 'Approved Training institutes' list, confirm the exact course is approved, and re-check the status on the day you pay. DG Shipping publishes suspensions and withdrawal orders.

Q13. What is the CDC?
The Continuous Discharge Certificate - your seafarer identity and service record booklet, issued by the Shipping Master through the Government Shipping Offices at Mumbai, Chennai and Kolkata. It costs Rs 700 and is valid for 10 years.

Q14. What is INDoS?
The Indian National Database of Seafarers. Your INDoS number is your user identity in DG Shipping's e-Governance system for CDC applications, sea-service records and examinations.

Q15. What is an RPSL?
A Recruitment and Placement Services Licence, issued under the Merchant Shipping (RPS) Rules, 2016. Indian seafarers must be recruited only through a valid RPSL company, whose live status is published on the DG Shipping website.

Q16. Can an agent charge me a placement fee?
No. An RPSL company may not charge a seafarer a recruitment or placement fee - its income comes from the ship-owning or manning company. Charging a seafarer is illegal in India.

Q17. What is Form-1 and why did it change?
It is the system-generated recruitment form you carry when joining a vessel. In 2025 it was replaced by three standardised, non-editable forms - Form-1, Form-1A and Form-1B - each with security features and an eMigrate ARN linked to your passport.

Q18. What happens if I am recruited through an unregistered agent?
The sea service is invalid and cannot be uploaded into the government system, you get no regulatory protection in disputes, and immigration may stop you. DG Shipping has documented exactly these consequences.

Q19. Who do I contact if I am cheated or blocked at an airport?
DG Shipping's 24x7 channels: email support.dgs@gov.in and crews.dgs@gov.in; phone or WhatsApp +91 90040 48406 and +91 86575 49760.

Q20. How long does it take to become a captain?
It depends on how continuously you sail, but the regulatory minimums stack up: 12 months of sea service for Second Mate, 18 months more as watchkeeping officer for Chief Mate, and three years as officer in charge of a navigational watch for Master - reducible to 30 months with a year as Chief Mate.

Q21. What does a captain earn?
Indicative market ranges put a Master at roughly Rs 5 lakh to Rs 8 lakh and above per month, varying widely by company, vessel type and flag. A deck cadet's stipend is far lower, typically Rs 25,000 to Rs 80,000 a month.

Q22. Is the pay tax-free?
Not automatically. It depends on your residence status. Under the seafarer day-count rule, the period of an eligible voyage - from the CDC join date to the sign-off date - is excluded from your days of stay

in India, which can affect whether you are resident. Confirm your own position with a qualified chartered accountant.

Q23. What is an eligible voyage for the tax rule?
A voyage by a ship carrying passengers or freight in international traffic, originating at an Indian port and ending at a foreign port, or originating abroad and ending at an Indian port.

Q24. How do I prove my sea service for tax?
The dates entered in your Continuous Discharge Certificate. Keep every CDC entry for every voyage - it is both your licensing evidence and your tax evidence.

Q25. What is a Certificate of Competency?
The licence that authorises you to serve in a particular rank, awarded by the administration after you meet the sea-service, training and examination requirements for that grade. It must be revalidated every five years.

Q26. Where are the CoC exams held?
At MMD centres in Mumbai, Chennai and Kolkata, and at additional centres for some grades. You apply for an eligibility assessment online through the e-Samudra portal, and a Form 29 is generated on approval.

Q27. Does all sea service count equally?
No. Rules require a substantial part of your sea service on trading vessels of specified tonnage, and time on non-trading or special-purpose vessels is credited at reduced rates - often two-thirds or half, with caps. Track your own totals.

Q28. What changed for MEO Class IV in 2027?
A 2026 circular introduces mandatory preparatory courses for MEO Class IV and ETO CoC examinations for candidates appearing for the first time on or after 1 January 2027. Approved institutes could start running them from 1 November 2026.

Q29. Can an engineering graduate join the engine side?
Yes, through the one-year Graduate Marine Engineering course. The 2026 draft eligibility circular widens the accepted streams to include approved allied branches, with an individual assessment available for borderline degrees.

Q30. Can an electrical graduate join?
Yes, through the Electro-Technical Officer route - a four-month pre-sea ETO course open to candidates with an electrical or electronics degree or diploma.

Q31. Are there opportunities for women?
Yes, and they are growing. The share of women among Indian seafarers rose from 0.78% in 2021 to 2.17% in 2025. The Maritime Training Trust offers support of up to Rs 1,00,000 to women cadets and ratings in pre-sea courses.

Q32. What if I do not clear IMU-CET?
The ratings route remains open - General Purpose Rating needs Class 10, not IMU-CET - and can lead upward with sea service. It is a slower road, not a dead end.

Q33. Is there life after a sea career?
Yes. Ship management, marine surveying, port operations, maritime law, insurance, chartering and maritime training all draw on sea experience, and the regulator itself uses sea-experienced officers for examiner and surveyor posts.

Q34. Do I need to be unmarried?

Many cadet programmes and sponsoring companies prefer unmarried candidates at entry, and some institutes state it as a condition. It varies - check the current prospectus for the course and company you are targeting.

Q35. What is the age limit?
It varies by course and institute. Cadet courses commonly take candidates from about 17 to 25. Check the specific prospectus, since age bands and relaxations differ.

Q36. How long is the training?
The deck diploma route is roughly one year of pre-sea training plus sea time; B.Sc Nautical Science is about three years plus sea time; B.Tech Marine Engineering is four years; GME is one year for graduates; the ETO pre-sea course is four months.

Q37. What is a Training Record Book?
The book in which your structured shipboard training and sea service are recorded and signed off by qualified officers. It is the evidence base for your Certificate of Competency eligibility - keep it current and safe.

Q38. Can I switch departments later?
There are defined pathways in some cases - for example, a 2026 circular establishes a transition route from Electro-Technical Officer to Marine Engineer Officer Class IV - but they are demanding and take years. Choose your department with care at the start.

Q39. Is the industry hiring?
Yes. India is the world's second-largest supplier of seafarers at about 3.12 lakh, and the national Mission 20% targets roughly 5.44 lakh by 2030. Global officer shortages add to demand.

Q40. What is the single most important thing I can do today?
Book a Class 2 medical or an Ishihara colour-vision test, and verify every institute and agent you deal with on the official government lists. Those two habits will protect you more than any other decision in this career.

SECTION 19

Official sources and links

Every rule, fee and figure in this playbook traces to one of the sources below. When something changes - and maritime regulation does change - these are where the change will appear first. Bookmark them.

Government portals

Source	What it covers	Where
Directorate General of Shipping	Approved MTIs, RPSL status, CDC, INDoS, forms, circulars and orders	dgshipping.gov.in
Directorate General of Maritime Administration	Nautical and engineering examination rules, circulars, career pages	dgma.gov.in
Indian Maritime University	IMU-CET notification, prospectus, admissions, fees	imu.edu.in
Mercantile Marine Departments (MMD)	CoC examination eligibility and centres	mmd.gov.in
Income Tax Department	Residence rules and the seafarer day-count provision	incometaxindia.gov.in
Press Information Bureau	Official statements on India's seafarer workforce and Mission 20%	pib.gov.in
Bureau of Immigration / eMigrate	eMigrate verification for seafarers	boi.gov.in and emigrate.gov.in

Key notices referenced in this playbook

- DG Shipping Training Circular 12 of 2020 - IMU-CET as the basis of admission to DG Shipping-regulated programmes.
- DGS Circular 55 of 2025 - advisory on unauthorised recruitment and placement agents.
- DGS Circular 56 of 2025 - introduction of revised Form-1, Form-1A and Form-1B.
- DGS Order No. 12 of 2026 - revision of CDC eligibility and seafarer quality standards, effective 1 August 2026.
- DGMA EAC Circular 49 of 2026 - mandatory preparatory courses for MEO Class IV and ETO CoC examinations from 1 January 2027.
- DGMA EAC Circular 50 of 2026 - transition pathway from Electro-Technical Officer to MEO Class IV.
- Draft DGMA EAC Circular (August 2026) - revised eligibility for the Graduate Marine Engineering course.
- DGS Order No. 03 of 2026 - mandatory Comprehensive Inspection Programme for DGS-approved Maritime Training Institutes.
- Merchant Shipping (STCW) Rules, 2014 - the sea-service and certification requirements behind the rank ladder.
- BIMCO/ICS Seafarer Workforce Report 2026, cited by PIB - the seafarer workforce figures.

A closing word

A career at sea is one of the few paths in India where a student from an ordinary background can reach a genuinely international, well-paid, senior profession through a defined set of exams and a certificate. The route is hard, the medical is unforgiving, and the fraud is real - but none of that is a reason to avoid it. It is a reason to do the reading, clear the medical first, verify everyone you deal with, and start early.

This playbook has tried to give you the map without the marketing. Use it, cross-check it against the official sources above, and go and get the licence.

Disclaimer

This playbook is an independent guide for general information. It is not legal, tax or professional advice, and it is not affiliated with or endorsed by the Directorate General of Shipping, the Indian Maritime University or any government body. Maritime rules, fees, dates and eligibility change; always confirm the current position on the official websites listed above before acting. For your personal tax position, consult a qualified chartered accountant.